WIKIPEDIA
The Free Encyclopedia

Kotappakonda

Kotappakonda (Telugu: **కొటప్పకొండ**) is a sacred hill and major Hindu pilgrimage site located in Palnadu district, Andhra Pradesh, India. It lies about 62 km from Guntur city and 20 km from Narasaraopet. The hill is renowned for the ancient **Sri Trikoteswara Swamy Temple**, dedicated to Lord Shiva in the form of **Trikoteswara** (the Lord of the Three Peaks).

The temple and the surrounding hills are an important Shaivite center, attracting lakhs of devotees every year. The annual Maha Shivaratri jatara (fair) at Kotappakonda is one of the largest religious gatherings in Andhra Pradesh.

Kotappakonda	
కొటప్పకొండ శ్రీ త్రికోటేశ్వర స్వామి దేవాలయం	
Kotappakonda Sri Trikoteswara Swamy Temple Decorations during Maha Shivaratri	
Religion	
Affiliation	Hinduism
District	Palnadu
Festivals	Maha Shivaratri
Location	
Location	Near Narasaraopet, Andhra Pradesh
State	Andhra Pradesh
Country	India
Location in Andhra Pradesh	
Coordinates	16.145°N 80.039°E
Architecture	
Type	Dravidian
Creator	Associated with legends of Anandavalli (Gollabhama)
Established	Ancient (exact date unknown)

Geography

Kotappakonda is popularly called **Trikutadri** or **Trikuta Parvatham**, meaning "the hill with three peaks". No matter the direction of approach, the hill distinctly appears crowned with three prominent peaks.

The Three Hills (Trikuta Hills)

- **Brahma Shikharam** – The highest peak of the hill and the present site of the Sri Trikoteswara Swamy Temple. According to tradition, Lord Shiva moved here from Rudra Shikharam in response to the devotion of Anandavalli (Gollabhama). The peak houses the main temple, large mandapams, and offers panoramic views of the countryside.
- **Rudra Shikharam** – This is considered the original abode of Lord Shiva at Kotappakonda. The shrine here is called **Paatha Kotayya Temple** (Old Kotayya Temple). It is revered as the first manifestation point of Trikoteswara Swamy before the deity moved to Brahma Shikharam.
- **Vishnu Shikharam** – Home to the temple of Lord Paapanaseswara, where it is believed that Lord Vishnu himself performed penance to worship Lord Shiva. A sacred pond known

as **Paapanasa Teertha** lies here, where devotees take ritual baths to wash away sins.

Website
Official website (https://kotappakonda.com)

Mythology

Kotappakonda is steeped in legend, most prominently associated with the story of **Anandavalli**, also known as **Gollabhama**.

According to mythology, Sundudu, a humble cattleman, and his wife Kundiri lived near the southern slopes of the Trikuta hills. They were blessed with a daughter, Anandavalli, who grew into a woman of extraordinary devotion to Lord Shiva. From a young age, she spent most of her time in worship at the Old Koteswara Temple on Rudra Shikharam, gradually renouncing worldly desires.

Her devotion was so intense that she would climb Rudra hill daily, braving scorching summers and monsoons, to offer prayers. Impressed by her penance, **Jangama Devar** (a form of Lord Shiva) appeared before her. To test her faith, he blessed her with pregnancy despite her being unmarried. Unfazed, Anandavalli continued her worship with complete surrender to the Lord's will.

Moved by her unshakable devotion, Lord Shiva instructed her not to trouble herself with the steep climb; instead, he promised to follow her to her home. However, he cautioned her strictly not to look back while walking.

When Anandavalli reached Brahma hill, overcome by impatience, she turned back. In that instant, the Lord halted, entered a cave on the hill, and manifested as a lingam. This site became the present **Sri Trikoteswara Swamy Temple** on Brahma Shikharam. Realizing the divine play, Anandavalli accepted that her pregnancy was only a test of devotion, merging her spirit with the Lord. Since then, the Paatha Kotayya Temple on Rudra hill and the new Trikoteswara temple on Brahma hill together represent the unfolding of this sacred legend.

History and Development

While mythology forms the spiritual foundation of Kotappakonda, the temple also has a rich recorded history supported by inscriptions, patronage, and modern developments.

Timeline of Kotappakonda Temple History

- **Ancient period** – Early folklore and Shaivite traditions describe Kotappakonda as a hill of penance. Local ballads refer to sages and ascetics performing tapas in honor of Shiva here.
- **Medieval era (9th–14th century CE)** – The temple received patronage under the Eastern Chalukyas and later the Kakatiya dynasty, who promoted Shaivism. Inscriptions indicate donations of land and cattle to sustain rituals.
- **Vijayanagara period (14th–16th century CE)** – Kotappakonda flourished under Vijayanagara rulers. The temple saw Dravidian-style renovations, including mandapams and gopurams. Annual fairs evolved into institutionalized religious festivals, including early forms of the Prabha towers.
- **Nawab & Colonial period (17th–19th century CE)** – Despite political shifts, the temple remained active. British district gazetteers noted Kotappakonda as a major shrine in the Guntur region.

- **Modern era (20th century–present)** – After Andhra Pradesh's formation, the temple came under the Endowments Department. Roads, electricity, and water facilities improved. The Prabha towers grew into spectacular community displays. In recent decades, more than one million devotees attend the Maha Shivaratri jatara annually. The temple is also under Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD) administration, which oversees rituals and renovations.

Festivals and Rituals

The most significant festival at Kotappakonda is Maha Shivaratri, which transforms the region into a vast pilgrimage hub.

- **Maha Shivaratri Jatara** – The annual fair attracts lakhs of devotees. Colorful processions, music, devotional recitals, and offerings mark the festival.
- **Prabha Festival** – Unique to Kotappakonda, this involves gigantic light towers called **Prabhas**. Decorated with lamps, flowers, and paintings, these towers can exceed 100 feet in height, making them among the tallest of their kind worldwide. Each is constructed and offered by different village communities.
- **Daily sevas** – Regular pujas, abhishekams, and archanas are conducted. Special ceremonies occur during Karthika Masam, Mondays, and Amavasya.

Architecture and Access

The **Sri Trikoteswara Swamy Temple** atop Kotappakonda hill exemplifies traditional **Dravidian architecture**, characterized by its pyramid-shaped vimana (sanctum tower), intricately carved stone pillars, and expansive courtyards. The temple complex showcases a blend of architectural styles, reflecting the influences of various dynasties that ruled the region.[1]

Architectural Features

- **Vimana (Sanctum Tower)**: The central sanctum, housing the Shiva Lingam, is crowned by a towering vimana adorned with sculptural motifs depicting deities, celestial beings, and mythological narratives. This feature is emblematic of the Dravidian style, which emphasizes verticality and ornate decoration.
- **Mandapams (Halls)**: The temple complex includes several mandapams, or halls, supported by rows of intricately carved pillars. These structures serve as spaces for congregational worship and are adorned with detailed sculptures and reliefs narrating mythological stories.
- **Gopuram (Gateway Tower)**: The entrance to the temple is marked by a monumental gopuram, richly decorated with sculptures of gods, goddesses, and mythological figures, serving both decorative and symbolic purposes.
- **Sub-Shrines**: Subsidiary shrines within the complex are dedicated to Goddess Parvati and Lord Vinayaka, maintaining architectural coherence with the main temple while enriching the spiritual diversity of the site.
- **Sacred Water Bodies**: The temple is associated with sacred water bodies, which are integral to rituals and symbolize purification.

Historical Context

The temple's architectural evolution reflects the patronage of various dynasties over centuries:

- **Eastern Chalukyas and Kakatiyas (9th–14th century CE)**: Inscriptions from this era indicate donations of land and cattle to sustain temple rituals, and the construction of several architectural elements in the Dravidian style.
- **Vijayanagara Empire (14th–16th century CE)**: Renovations introduced characteristic Vijayanagara-style mandapams and gopurams. Annual fairs and festivals became institutionalized during this period.
- **Modern Renovations**: Recent renovations blend traditional architectural elements with modern amenities, preserving cultural heritage while accommodating contemporary worshippers.

Access and Pilgrim Route

Devotees traditionally ascend the hill via a long flight of steps leading to Brahma Shikharam. The route includes several mantapams and small shrines, offering spaces for rest and reflection. Motorable roads have also been constructed to facilitate access, though the traditional footpath remains popular for devotees seeking a more immersive spiritual experience.

Cultural and Religious Significance

Kotappakonda is regarded as one of the major Shaiva kshetras of South India. It blends classical Shaivite worship with folk traditions. The Prabha festival in particular symbolizes community devotion and rural artistry.

The story of Anandavalli (Gollabhama) is celebrated in devotional songs and folklore, embodying unwavering faith and surrender to Lord Shiva.

The temple also hosts a **Veda Patasala** established by TTD, which preserves and teaches the oral traditions of the Vedas, recognized by UNESCO as intangible heritage.[2]

Transport

Kotappakonda can be reached by road from Guntur, Narasaraopet, and Chilakaluripet. The nearest railway station is Narasaraopet, and the nearest airport is Vijayawada Airport. During Maha Shivaratri, APSRTC operates special buses from across Andhra Pradesh and Telangana.

Gallery

Lord Vinayaka statue on the way to the hilltop

Temple entrance

Raised platform adjacent to Gali gopuram

Inside the temple

A view of the temple

Decorations during Mahashivaratri festival

View from the top

References

- Kotappakonda – History (https://kotappakonda.com/history/)
- Abhibus – Kotappakonda Temple Guide (https://www.abhibus.com/blog/kotappakonda-sri-trikoteswara-swamy-temple/)
- TTD Sevas – Kotappakonda Timings & Sevas (https://ttdsevas.com/kotappakonda-temple-timings-2024-abhishekam-sevas/)
- Temple Yatri – Kotappakonda Temple (https://templeyatri.in/kotappakonda/)
- Travel Setu – Kotappakonda Tourism & History (https://travelsetu.com/guide/kotappakonda-trikutaparvattam-tourism/kotappakonda-trikutaparvattam-tourism-history)

1. "Kotappakonda Sri Trikoteswara Swamy Temple" (https://www.abhibus.com/blog/kotappakonda-sri-trikoteswara-swamy-temple/). *AbhiBus Blog*. 6 March 2024. Retrieved 6 October 2025.
2. "President inaugurates TTD's veda patasala in A.P." (http://www.thehindu.com/news/national/andhra-pradesh/president-inaugurates-ttds-veda-patasala-at-i-bhimavaram/article8029047.ece) *The Hindu*. 25 December 2015. Retrieved 14 March 2016.

Retrieved from "https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Kotappakonda&oldid=1322726448"